. Dr Bryce, just on entering the pass, was shot through the chest, and when dying handed his will to Captain Marshall.[51]

‘Little or no resistance was made by the sepoys,’ noted Elphinstone in his official memorandum to the government, ‘most of whom had lost their fingers or toes, and their muskets covered with frozen snow would have been little use even if the men could have handled them. The slaughter was frightful and when we reached Kubber Jubber [actually Khak-i-Jabar] fighting men were with difficulty distinguished from camp followers. Most had thrown away their arms and accoutrements; and fell an easy prey to our barbarous and bloodthirsty foe.’[52] As ever, the orders given by Elphinstone only made things worse. ‘Our military authorities, who proved themselves as incapable of conducting a retreat as they had previously shown themselves in the operations preceding it, had with the most strange perversity ordered our men on no account to return the fire,’ wrote Lawrence. ‘The consequence was that their ranks were forced in, and an indiscriminate slaughter of unresisting men followed all the way to Tezin?. . .’[53] ‘We were in so thick a mass,’ wrote an exhausted and despairing Johnson, ‘that every shot told on some part or other of the column.’[54]

By the evening of 11 January, after yet another day-long massacre, as the ever diminishing column stumbled out of the Tezin Pass towards the fertile valley-bottom village of Jagdalak, the number of casualties passed 12,000. There were only 200 troops still left to stumble forward. The small rearguard was under the command of Shelton, who now for the first time showed his steel as he stood at the back of the column holding the Afghans at bay. ‘Nothing could exceed the bravery of Shelton,’ wrote Johnson. ‘He was like a bulldog assaulted on all sides by a lot of curs trying to snap at his head, tail and sides. Shelton’s small band was attacked by horse and foot, and although the latter were fifty to one, not a man dared to come close . . . We cheered him in true English fashion as he descended into the valley, notwithstanding we, at the time, were acting as targets for the marksmen of the enemy on the hills.’

That night, as the remaining troops lay besieged and starving in a small ruined mud-walled enclosure in Jagdalak, Akbar Khan summoned General Elphinstone and Brigadier Shelton for negotiations. Hugh Johnson accompanied them. ‘We found the Sirdar and his party bivouacked in the open air,’ he wrote. ‘Nothing could exceed the kind and apparently